

**Stand *out*
whenever
you Speak**

MANAGING
DIFFICULT
CONVERSATIONS

Participant Field Guide

MASTER SEVEN
KEY SKILLS







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THIS GUIDE

This guide will provide everything you need to know about managing difficult conversations. It is based on the excellent book "Crucial Conversations" written by Kerry Patterson, Joseph Grenny, Ron McMillan, and Al Switzer and, "Your Brain at Work" by David Rock.

Please enjoy!



SECTION 1

WHAT ARE DIFFICULT CONVERDATIONS?



Every day, all of us are engaged in conversations. Some are more important than others, some more relaxed than others. However, when the stakes are high, emotions run strong and opinions vary, conversations can become difficult.

We might say something that makes complete sense in the moment but think about it later as a big misstep. Or, in the moment, we withdraw, thinking that saying something, anything at all, is not worth it. Difficult conversations can happen in an instant, or sometimes we can see them coming.

Either way, it is important that we handle difficult conversations well.

SECTION 2

YOUR STYLE UNDER STRESS

DIRECTIONS: Because the results are situational, think of a specific situation, involving a specific group of people. Click either TRUE or FALSE for each question and score the results on Results page (#2).

TRUE	FALSE	1. At times I avoid situations that might bring me into contact with people I'm having problems with.	TRUE	FALSE	12. If I really get into a heated discussion, I've been known to be tough on the other person. In fact, they might even feel a bit insulted or hurt.	TRUE	FALSE	23. I sometimes make absolute statements like "The fact is..." or "It's obvious that..." to be sure my point gets across.
TRUE	FALSE	2. I have put off returning phone calls or e-mails because I simply didn't want to deal with the person who sent them.	TRUE	FALSE	13. When I'm discussing an important topic with others, sometimes I move from trying to make my point to trying to win the battle.	TRUE	FALSE	24. If others hesitate to share their views, I sincerely invite them to say what's on their mind, no matter what it is.
TRUE	FALSE	3. Sometimes when people bring up a touchy or awkward issue I try to change the subject.	TRUE	FALSE	14. In the middle of a tough conversation, I often get so caught up in arguments that I don't see how I'm coming across to others.	TRUE	FALSE	25. I sometimes feel so frustrated or put down that I come across pretty aggressively toward the other person.
TRUE	FALSE	4. When it comes to dealing with awkward or stressful subjects, sometimes I hold back rather than give my full and candid opinion.	TRUE	FALSE	15. When talking gets tough and I do something hurtful, I'm quick to apologize for my mistakes.	TRUE	FALSE	26. Even when things get tense, I adapt quickly to how others are responding to me and try a new strategy.
TRUE	FALSE	5. Rather than tell people exactly what I think, sometimes I rely on jokes, sarcasm, or snide remarks to let them know I'm frustrated.	TRUE	FALSE	16. When I think about a conversation that took a bad turn, I tend to focus first on what I did that was wrong rather than focus on others' mistakes.	TRUE	FALSE	27. When I find that I'm at cross purposes with someone, I often keep trying to win my way rather than looking for common ground.
TRUE	FALSE	6. When I've got something tough to bring up, sometimes I offer weak or insincere compliments to soften the blow.	TRUE	FALSE	17. I'm pretty good at persuading others by helping them understand the reasoning behind my views.	TRUE	FALSE	28. When things don't go well, I'm more inclined to see the mistakes others made than notice my own role.
TRUE	FALSE	7. In order to get my point across, I sometimes exaggerate my side of the argument.	TRUE	FALSE	18. I can tell very quickly when others are holding back or feeling defensive in a conversation.	TRUE	FALSE	29. After I share strong opinions, I go out of my way to invite others to share their views, particularly opposing ones.
TRUE	FALSE	8. If I seem to be losing control of a conversation, I might cut people off or change the subject in order to bring it back to where I think it should be.	TRUE	FALSE	19. Sometimes I decide it's better not to give harsh feedback because I know it's bound to cause problems.	TRUE	FALSE	30. When others hesitate to share their views, I do whatever I can to make it safe for them to speak honestly.
TRUE	FALSE	9. When others make points that seem stupid to me, I sometimes let them know it without holding back at all.	TRUE	FALSE	20. When conversations aren't working, I step back from the fray, think about what's happening, and take steps to make it better.	TRUE	FALSE	31. I often have problems with people failing to do what we agreed to and then the burden is on me to bring it up again.
TRUE	FALSE	10. When I'm stunned by a comment, sometimes I say things that others might take as forceful or attacking—terms such as "Give me a break!" or "That's	TRUE	FALSE	21. When others get defensive because they misunderstand me, I immediately get us back on track by clarifying what I do and don't mean.	TRUE	FALSE	32. I find myself in situations where people get their feelings hurt because they thought they would have more of a say in final decisions than they end up having.
TRUE	FALSE	11. Sometimes when things get a bit heated I move from arguing against others' points to saying things that might hurt them personally.	TRUE	FALSE	22. There are some people I'm rough on because, to be honest, they need or deserve what I give them.	TRUE	FALSE	33. I get frustrated sometimes at how long it takes some groups to make decisions because too many people are involved.

SECTION 2

YOUR STYLE UNDER STRESS

Scorecard - Directions

To complete the Score Card, please do the following.

Match each question in the survey with its counterpart in the scorecard. If your answer on the survey corresponds with the answer on the scorecard, mark it with an **X**. If not, leave it blank.

Complete the Score Card in this manner.

Timid	vs.	Livid
Masking		Controlling
5 (T)		7 (T)
6 (T)		8 (T)
Avoiding		Labelling
3 (T)		9 (T)
4 (T)		10 (T)
Withdrawing		Attacking
1 (T)		11 (T)
2 (T)		12 (T)
Fewer is Better		

We not Me	Humbly Confident
13 (F)	17 (T)
19 (F)	23 (F)
25 (F)	29 (T)
Look Out	Sincerely Curious
14 (F)	18 (T)
20 (T)	24 (T)
26 (T)	30 (T)
Mutual Purpose	Move to Action
15 (F)	31 (F)
21 (T)	32 (F)
27 (F)	33 (F)
Stick to Facts	More is Better
16 (T)	
22 (F)	
28 (F)	

What Your Score Means

Once complete, look at **PART A**. The score tells you if you typically use Timid or Livid styles when you're under stress. The fewer **X's** in **PART A**, the better.

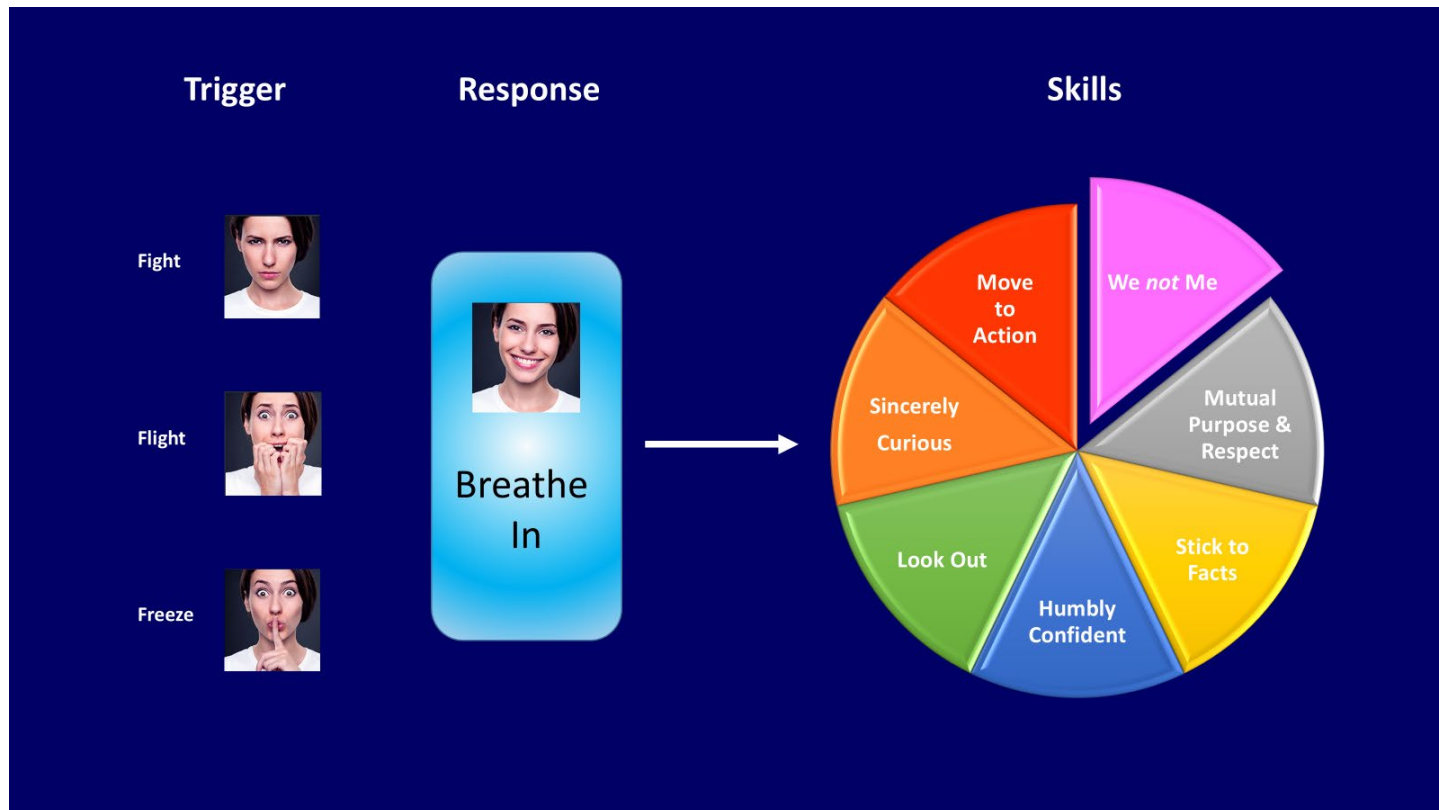
PART B shows how well, or not, you currently leverage the seven successful, difficult conversation skills. Total the number of check marks and put the total in the grey box displayed for each skill. If you score high in any of these dimensions (2 or 3 **X's**), you're likely quite skilled in it already. If however, you score low (0 or 1 **X's**), you may want to learn more about these skills.

SECTION 3

SEVEN KEY SKILLS

We were all taught as kids that we should think before we speak. It seems simple enough. Then why don't we do it when we find ourselves in the midst of a difficult conversation? Truth is, in high stress situations, our brain short circuits and our amygdala hijacks our brain as a way to protect us. The downside is that we immediately go into either a fight, flight, or freeze mode.

In order to deploy one or more of the seven key skills to successfully managing difficult conversations we need to learn to breathe in as soon as a conversation turns difficult. It does two things; first, when we breathe in, it is impossible to say anything and second, it gives us the time to think about what we should say and do to keep the conversation on the rails.



SECTION 3

SEVEN KEY SKILLS

Here are brief descriptions of the seven skills.

1. **We not Me**

- What you really want for yourself... others ... your relationship

2. **Mutual Purpose & Respect** ... make it comfortable for all to talk

- Establish a mutual purpose
- Work for a common outcome
- Establish mutual respect
- Show you care about their goals ... interests ... values
- Look for similarities in others not differences

3. **Stick to Facts**

- Do not play
 - Victim ... "It's not my fault"
 - Villain ... "It's all your fault"
 - Helpless ... "There's nothing else I can do"

4. **Be Humbly Confident**

- Speak persuasively ... not abrasively
- Acknowledge that there may be a difference in viewpoints
- Your goal is not to persuade others that you are right
- Instead, you want to add to the discussion

5. **Look Out**

- Notice changes in your and others' behaviour

6. **Be Sincerely Curious** ... even if we know what they will say

- Ask open ended questions ... listen attentively ... do not interrupt
- Paraphrase for understanding ... honour their position
- Mirror others' tonality and gestures... empathize

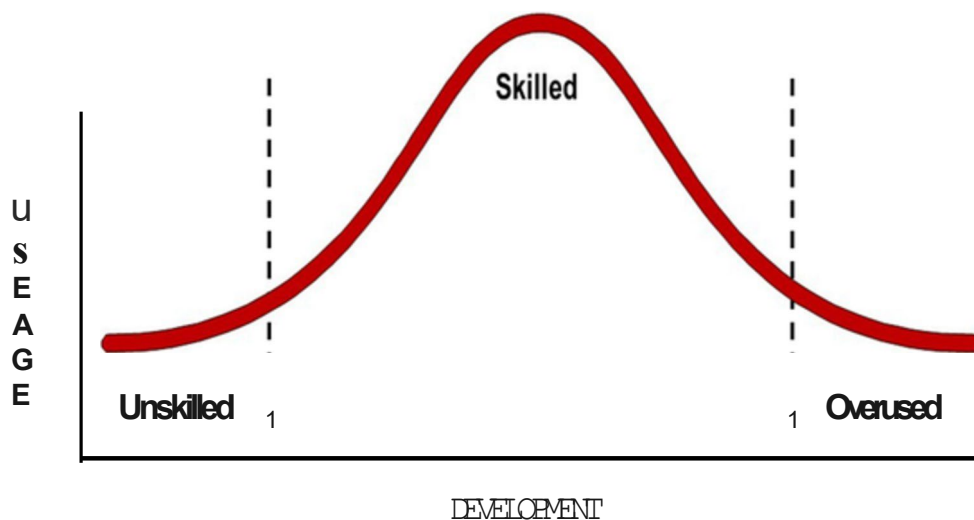
7. **Move to Action**

- Agree up front how decisions will be made ... who does what by when

SECTION 4

SKILL DEVELOPMENT

Keep in mind, the seven skills outlined above need to be practiced. Just like learning to speak a second language, to play the piano or golf, it is not enough to know, even understand these skills, it is necessary to hone them to a fine degree of proficiency. Also look out for times when these skills become overused and turn into a weakness. For example, being curious can become annoying if taken too far.



SECTION 5

SCARF MODEL

S TATUS

People want to feel respected, appreciated

"I am valuable"

C ERTAINTY

People want things to be predictable, understandable

"I know where I stand"

A UTONOMY

People want to make decisions about matters that affect them

"I have a choice"

R ELATEDNESS

People are tribal, they want to feel as though they belong

"I belong"

F AIRNESS

People want to be treated fairly

"I am treated with respect"

APPENDIX A

DIFFICULT CONVERSATION PLANNER

1. We <u>not</u> Me - What Do You Really Want? Which issue do you need to address? For yourself? _____ _____ For the other person? _____ _____ For the relationship? _____ _____ For the organization? _____ _____ 2. Mutual Purpose & Respect What is an agreeable common outcome (Mutual Purpose)? How can you establish it? _____ In what ways are you similar (Mutual Respect)? _____ How can you demonstrate care for the other person's goals, interests & values? _____ How can you demonstrate empathy? _____ 3. Stick to Facts What are the important facts (who/what/where/when/why/how)? _____ _____ What are you telling yourself about the situation or the person (Victim, Villain, Helpless) that aren't facts? _____ _____ What will help you stick to the facts? _____ _____ _____	4. Be Humbly Confident How will you start the conversation? _____ _____ What open-ended questions will you ask to keep the conversation on track? _____ How will you share facts confidently, persuasively yet humbly? _____ 5. Look Out How will you spot changes in your behaviour (i.e. in what you say & do) to know the conversation is becoming difficult? _____ _____ How will you spot changes in the other's behaviour? _____ If the other person misunderstands your intent, what is a contrasting statement you could use? I Don't: _____ I Do: _____ 6. Be Sincerely Curious How will you encourage their point of view? _____ How will you ask, acknowledge & listen...attentively? _____ How can you use mirroring & paraphrasing skills? _____ How can you demonstrate presence & patience? _____ 7. Move to Action Have roles been assigned? To Whom? _____ Will do what? _____ By when? _____
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A P P E N D I X B

HELPFUL HINTS

about what to say and what not to say

Skills	What	How	
		Say	Don't Say
Make it about 'We' <u>not</u> 'Me'	- You pay attention to what you really want for yourself...for others...for the relationship. - You act in ways that are consistent with your true motives.	"We do need to talk about this." "I'm glad you asked." "You're right, that is important." "Thanks for taking the risk." "That's an important insight, hadn't thought of it." "I see now what you mean."	"Seriously!" "Are you kidding!" "Come on already." "Give me a break." "What were you thinking!" "You're wrong..." "I'd prefer to stay out of this!"
Establish Mutual Purpose & Respect	- You spot a difficult conversation, and make it comfortable for all to talk. - You establish a Mutual Purpose - Others perceive you are working for a common outcome - That you care about their goals, interests and values - You establish Mutual Respect - Look for similarities in others not differences - You empathize	"I don't want you to think...I do want you to think..." "Can we change gears for a moment, I'd like to talk about..." "It's ok if we don't see eye to eye." "What I'd love is for us to come up with a solution." "I'm sorry, the last thing I want you to think is..." "I think your ideas are great."	- Nothing! "Where did you get <i>that</i> idea?" "Yeah ok, whatever you say." "I have a sinking feeling about this." "Yeah, like that's going to happen." "That can't be right!"
Stick to Facts	- You don't play the role of: - Victim ("It's all your fault") - Villain ("It's all your fault") - Helpless ("There's nothing else I can do")	"That must have been difficult to say, thank you." "I appreciate your honesty." "Your opinion means a lot, thanks." "You've given me a great deal to think about."	"You made me mad!" "It's not my fault!" "It's all your fault!" "You're wrong!" "There's nothing else I can do!" "Don't be so sensitive!"
Be Humbly Confident	- You speak persuasively, not abrasively. - You display a blend of confidence and humility. - Your goal is not to persuade others that you are right, - Rather that you want your words to be added to the pool for discussion.	"Let's hear the other side of the story." "In my opinion..." "I'm beginning to wonder..." "I can see why you feel that way." "This sounds very important to you." "Please don't worry about hurting my feelings."	"That will never work!" "We tried that before!" "The fact is..." "Call me crazy, but..." "Everything I said is clear & doesn't need repeating." "That's how I see it. Nobody disagrees, do they?"
Look Out	- You look for when a conversation is becoming difficult. - You notice changes in your and others' behaviour as conversations become difficult.	"You seem upset, how can I help?" "I need your help with what just happened." "Do you have a few minutes to talk?"	"Excuse me, I have to take this call." "We tried that, what a disaster." "Your ideas need a lot of work." "Don't listen to them, they're from Head Office." "Try that stupid stunt and see what happens." "Someone woke up on the wrong side of the bed."
Be Sincerely Curious	- You ask sincere questions and listen attentively. - You mirror others' tonality and gestures. - You paraphrase for understanding.	"What am I missing?" "I'd really like to hear what you have to say." "What can I say to persuade you?" "Let's see if I got that right?" "What do you think might work?" "I didn't realize, can you tell me more?" "I need your help, can we talk?"	"Wrong! You forgot to mention..." "Just spit it out!" "Have you got an answer or not?" "I'm not asking you, I'm telling you!"
Move to Action	- You agree up front how decisions will be made. - You determine who does what by when.	"It's time we all got together to make this happen." "Let me know when you've completed your piece."	"Let's figure out our 'To Do's' later."

Wrap Up

There you have it; all you need to manage difficult conversations successfully ...at any time, with anyone.

Remember, success depends not only on understanding the principles contained in this guide, but like any skill, practicing them too.

Go for it!



ABOUT

B A R R Y K U N T Z

**Managing Director
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Barry is a captivating presenter and trainer and executive coach. Known as a motivator, team builder, and collaborator, Barry is both passionate and talented at helping individuals, teams and organizations achieve their best.

Before joining Black Isle as Managing Director, Barry held senior executive positions at General Motors of Canada Ltd. in sales, service, marketing, and public affairs. His book, "PAUSE: Standout Whenever You Speak" has been widely acclaimed.

Since joining Black Isle, he has embarked on a journey that has been uplifting, inspiring, and rewarding; helping leaders to stand out, whenever they speak. As a certified practitioner in the Dr. Reuven Bar-On method, Barry also enjoys coaching executives to become more effective at emotional intelligence, helping them to manage behaviour, navigate social complexities, and make decisions that achieve positive results.

Barry has worked with senior executives from RBC, BMO, CIBC, Citibank, Barclay's Bank, Bank of Canada, Canaccord Genuity, Manulife Financial, TJX Canada, Enbridge Gas, Lubrizol, Deloitte Consulting, McKinsey & Company, Wrigley, Ontario Pension Board, Unilever, Clorox, Madison Square Garden, Coeur Mining, JLL Partners, Nissan and General Motors of Canada, as well as politicians, presidents of Canadian universities, TEDx Speakers and Dragon's Den contestants.

Barry is a graduate from the University of Saskatchewan with a Bachelor of Administration degree. He is an active supporter of numerous charities having sat on the Board of Directors for the Canadian Medic Alert Foundation, the Traffic Injury Foundation, the Yves Landry Foundation Board, as well as the Grandview Children's Foundation, and as a trustee for the Robert McLaughlin Art Gallery.

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